

Time signatures

At the beginning of a piece of music, we mark the meter using a time signature. It tells us the number of beats in each measure and the time value of each beat.

SEE ALSO

◀ 24–25 Beats and measures

◀ 26–27 Note values

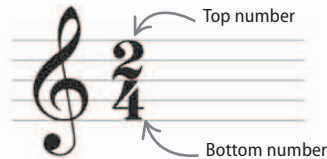
◀ 28–29 Beams and dots

Compound time 32–33 ▶

Grouping notes 36–37 ▶

Naming the meter

When we talk about the meter in a piece of music, we say, for instance, “two-four,” with the top number first. If we are writing text, we can write “2/4,” but we must remember that it is not a fraction.

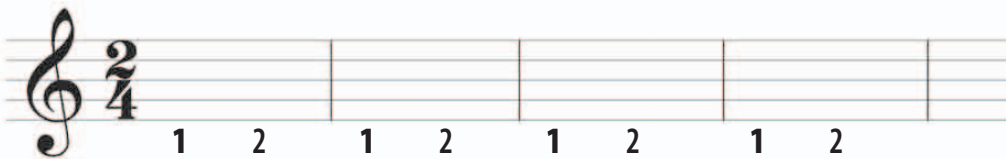


◀ Time signature

There is a top and a bottom number, but a time signature is not a fraction.

The top number

This shows how many beats there are in each measure. It tells us how to count as we read or play the music. Similarly, it tells a conductor how to beat time.



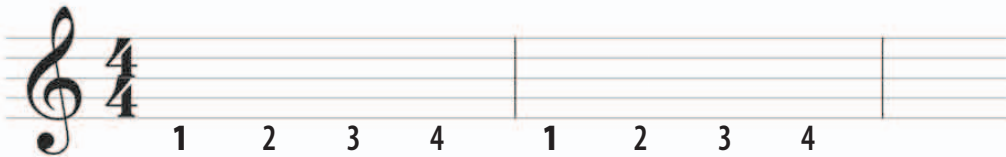
◀ 2/4 time signature

If the top number is 2, there are two beats in each measure. Marches are often in 2/4.



◀ 3/4 time signature

If the top number is 3, there are three beats in each measure. Waltzes and minuetts are normally in 3/4.



◀ 4/4 time signature

If the top number is 4, there are four beats in each measure. 4/4 is sometimes called “common time.”

The bottom number

The bottom number describes which note value is used for the beat. When the bottom number is 4, as in these examples, it means the beat is a quarter note. The quarter note is the most common note value for a beat.



◀ 4/4 time signature

There are four beats in each measure, and the beats are quarter notes.



◀ 3/4 time signature

There are three beats in each measure, and the beats are quarter notes.